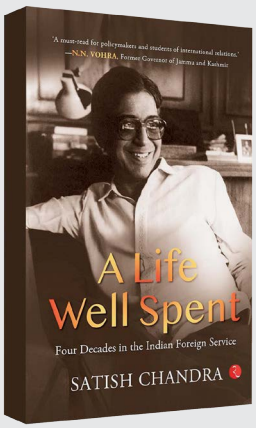
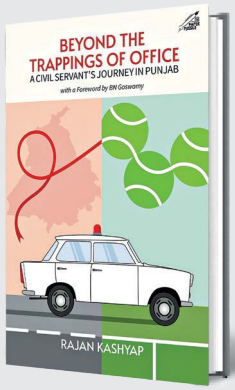
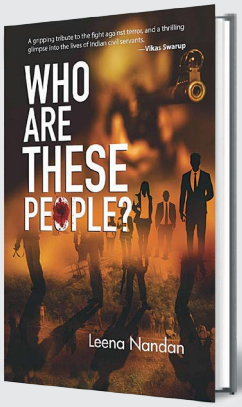
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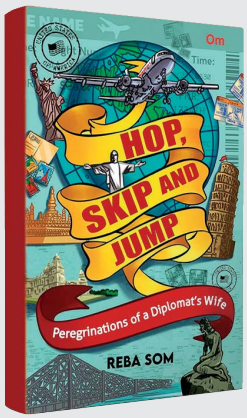




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BOOKS

CIVIL LINES

A quartet of books provides a window into the lives of Indian bureaucrats besides showcasing their felicity with the written word

Indian literature across languages has always had a tradition of books by both bureaucrats and diplomats—think of the Hindi poet Ashok Vajpeyi, the Odia novelist Gopinath Mohanty or, more recently, English-language novelists like Shashi Tharoor, Navtej Sarna, et al. Thanks to their unique administrative positionality, they are ideally suited to observe a region's insecurities and idiosyncrasies. A recent bunch of books—three memoirs and a novel—do a good job of describing the highs and lows of the IAS/ IFS life.

Satish Chandra's memoir *A Life Well Spent* is a great starting point for those who wish to know more about the workings of diplomacy in general and the IFS in particular. During his long and distinguished career (1965-2005), Chandra was posted in Geneva, Vienna, Dhaka, Islamabad and a bunch of other places. He also got to serve on crucial governmental bodies like the 1965 Pillai Committee, set up to "review the organisation and working of the IFS". Chandra's recollections of these phases in his career are generous without sugar-coating anybody's actions (including his own). Even when you don't agree with him (for example, I disagree with his assertion that journalists working in conflict areas like Kashmir or the Northeast ought to have a measure of nationalism within them), you'll find his storytelling style quite agreeable.

Rajan Kashyap's erudition and wit are apparent in every chapter of Beyond the Trappings of Choice

In a similar vein, Rajan Kashyap's *Beyond the Trappings of Office: A Civil Servant's Journey in Punjab* recalls the retired civil servant's 38-year-old career, most of which he spent working in Punjab, retiring as Chief Secretary. Kashyap's erudition and wit are apparent in every chapter—his personal crusade against red tape, negotiating the specificity of Punjab's agricultural issues, his memories of Punjab's dark days and Operation Blue Star, a 2004 visit to "the other Punjab" across the border (the Pakistani province of Punjab). All of these are covered with warmth and humility and, occasionally, literary flair. For example, during the chapter about the Pakistan visit, he quotes John Keats' poem *The Naughty Boy* to underline his sense of incredulity at finding the two Punjabs very similar.

Leena Nandan's *Who Are These People?* is a work of fiction, a crime thriller involving a terrorism plot—and a group of plucky bureaucrats from